

What if Mass Eats the Vacuum?

Mass as a Sink of Zero-Point Radiation: A Classical Alternative to General Relativity

David Plotz

June 16th, 2025

Abstract

This paper introduces a classical field theory of gravity built on the Maxwell equations and a central physical hypothesis: that mass absorbs zero-point radiation, inducing a net inward momentum flow. Drawing from stochastic electrodynamics (SED), we postulate a Lorentz-invariant radiation field present throughout space and hypothesize that mass acts as a sink for this field. We construct a consistent model of a massive particle, demonstrate energy and momentum conservation, and derive an emergent Dirac equation via a spinor transformation. Classical tests of general relativity, including Mercury's precession, gravitational lensing, and gravitational redshift, are reproduced to leading order. This approach provides a novel, Lorentz-invariant, classical alternative to quantum gravity and general relativity, and lays a foundation for further exploration.

1 Introduction

Modern physics is built on two towering achievements: quantum mechanics, which explains the behavior of atoms and particles, and general relativity, which describes gravity and the large-scale structure of the universe. Each theory works astonishingly well in its own realm.

But they don't fit together. When applied simultaneously, the equations break down and yield infinities. Despite nearly a century of effort, no unifying framework has emerged. Proposals like string theory offer elegant mathematics, but no concrete predictions we can test. The field has grown stagnant, dominated by a few entrenched ideas. A fresh approach is warranted.

This paper proposes that fresh approach. Rather than quantizing gravity or geometrizing quantum mechanics, we propose that mass acts as a *sink* for zero-point radiation, inducing a directional flow of momentum in the surrounding field.

1.1 Roadmap

This paper is structured to follow the logic of the scientific method: we begin with a hypothesis, outline the physical assumptions that support it, explore its mathematical consequences, compare its predictions to experiment, and finally examine whether it offers a deeper conceptual shift.

Every theory begins with a hypothesis. If it yields interesting physics and does not contradict experiment, it deserves to be taken seriously. The history of science is full of ideas that sounded outlandish at first but reshaped our understanding. The burden is not on the hypothesis to sound reasonable—it's on the results to be meaningful. In **Section 2**, we introduce the core hypothesis: that mass acts as a sink for momentum from a pervasive background radiation field. We first present the idea intuitively, anchoring the theory in a physical picture, and then spell it out mathematically.

In **Sections 3 and 4**, we lay out the core physical assumptions underlying the hypothesis. By “assumptions,” we mean elements already present in the scientific literature—perhaps unconventional, but not novel to this work. **Section 3** adopts a Maxwell-style framework for gravity, building on gravito-electromagnetism. **Section 4** introduces the stochastic radiation field—drawn from stochastic electrodynamics—as the physical medium from which mass absorbs momentum.

Sections 5 and 6 contain the technical core of the paper. We introduce two natural cutoffs, in space and frequency, that regulate the mass-field interaction and ensure physical consistency. We then analyze whether the inflow of radiation can provide a stabilizing mechanism for mass, counteracting gravitational self-energy.

In **Section 7**, we test the theory against observation. We demonstrate that it reproduces the classical predictions of general relativity to leading order: perihelion precession, gravitational lensing, and redshift.

Finally, in **Section 8**, we turn to the most surprising result: the field equations, when transformed through a mathematical duality, yield the Dirac equation. A single classical theory thus encompasses gravity, electromagnetism, and quantum behavior, without invoking quantization.

Section 9 concludes with a discussion of open questions, potential avenues for further investigation, and the broader implications of the framework proposed here.

2 The Core Hypothesis

2.1 A Physical Picture: Radiation Sink Intuition

Before introducing equations, we present a simple physical picture to guide intuition. Consider a neutral, perfectly conducting iron sphere, heated until it glows red. When placed in the vacuum of space, it emits infrared radiation and cools down, eventually approaching absolute zero.

But even at zero Kelvin, space is not truly empty. Both classical and quantum theories suggest the presence of a background electromagnetic field—commonly called the zero-point radiation field. "Zero-point" refers to zero-temperature; "radiation" in this context means light. A fuller treatment of this will be offered in **Section 4**. For now, it is enough to imagine a low-level radiation noise present even in the coldest vacuum. The mass absorbs radiation from this ambient field.

The hypothesis proposed here is that mass absorbs energy from the zero-point field even at absolute zero. This interaction produces a net inward flow of momentum toward the mass.

The remainder of the paper builds from this intuition and develops the consequences of this idea.

2.2 Core Hypothesis: The Math

The image above anchors the theory.

If mass always interacts with the zero-point field, then this interaction must have physical consequences. We propose it manifests as an inward-pointing momentum density:

$$\boxed{\mathbf{P}(r) = -\hat{\mathbf{r}} \frac{Gm\hbar}{r^2}} \quad (1)$$

A photon traveling through this field experiences a cumulative momentum shift:

$$\Delta \mathbf{p} = \int_{\text{path}} \mathbf{P}(r) dl \quad (2)$$

This is our core hypothesis, and its implications will be tested in **Section 7**.

This is a proposed hypothesis: mass creates a momentum flux capable of acting on radiation.

Here, in the current iteration of this paper, we simply state the hypothesis and explore its consequences. In future drafts or subsequent work, we hope to derive this form directly from the two assumptions laid out in the next sections.

A few questions are prompted by this hypothesis: Can such a flow obey conservation of energy and momentum? Can it stabilize mass against collapse? Can it account for known gravitational phenomena?

3 Maxwell-Like Equations for Gravity

Our gravitational field theory begins with a structural analogy: just as electromagnetism is governed by Maxwell’s equations, we propose that gravity obeys a similar set of vector field equations. These equations follow the form of Maxwell’s equations in electromagnetism, but with mass and mass current acting as sources rather than charge and electric current. In natural units ($c = 1$):

$$\begin{aligned}\nabla \times \mathbf{B} - \partial_t \mathbf{E} &= -4\pi G \mathbf{J}, & \nabla \times \mathbf{E} + \partial_t \mathbf{B} &= 0 \\ \nabla \cdot \mathbf{E} &= -4\pi G \rho, & \nabla \cdot \mathbf{B} &= 0\end{aligned}\tag{3}$$

These equations describe a vector field sourced by mass density ρ and mass current $\mathbf{J}$, with G playing the role of the coupling constant.

Some may be surprised by the presence of $\mathbf{B}$, a magnetic-like field. But this emerges naturally: just as a moving charge generates a magnetic field, a moving mass generates a “gravitomagnetic” field. While static masses generate only $\mathbf{E}$, moving masses induce $\mathbf{B}$; however, the effect is negligible unless the mass is both extremely large and rapidly moving. **Section 7** discusses a physical manifestation of this effect and explores its potential testability..

3.1 Irrotational and Solenoidal Decomposition

Any vector field can be split into irrotational (curl-free) and solenoidal (divergence-free) components:

$$\mathbf{V} = \mathbf{V}_I + \mathbf{V}_S, \quad \nabla \cdot \mathbf{V}_S = 0, \quad \nabla \times \mathbf{V}_I = 0\tag{4}$$

Applying this to our gravitational fields yields two decoupled subsystems:

Static Fields (Irrotational):

$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E}_I = -4\pi G \rho, \quad \partial_t \mathbf{E}_I = 4\pi G \mathbf{J}_I, \quad \nabla \cdot \mathbf{J}_I + \partial_t \rho = 0\tag{5}$$

Radiation Fields (Solenoidal):

$$\nabla \times \mathbf{B}_S - \partial_t \mathbf{E}_S = 4\pi G \mathbf{J}_S, \quad \nabla \times \mathbf{E}_S + \partial_t \mathbf{B}_S = 0\tag{6}$$

This decomposition reflects a meaningful physical distinction between the **static gravitational attraction** and the **propagating radiation** field.

In the rest frame of the mass, these sectors decouple. One set of equations governs the gravitational field sourced by the mass, while another describes the radiation field. This separation enables a detailed analysis of radiation without affecting the static component.

We can make this explicit by defining a new current:

$$\mathbf{J}'_{\mathbf{S}} = -G\mathbf{J}_{\mathbf{S}} \quad (7)$$

This transforms the inhomogeneous solenoidal equation into:

$$\nabla \times \mathbf{B}_S - \partial_t \mathbf{E}_S = 4\pi \mathbf{J}'_{\mathbf{S}} \quad (8)$$

while leaving all other equations unchanged.

Since this form matches the standard presentation in textbooks on electromagnetic radiation, we will drop the prime and adopt the following as the solenoidal (radiation) Maxwell equations:

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla \times \mathbf{B}_S - \partial_t \mathbf{E}_S &= 4\pi \mathbf{J}_S \\ \nabla \times \mathbf{E}_S + \partial_t \mathbf{B}_S &= 0 \end{aligned} \quad (9)$$

3.2 Spherical Vector Harmonics

The following sections derive the explicit solutions to the Maxwell equations used in this theory.

Due to the symmetric radial symmetry of the problem, we will benefit from using Vector Spherical Harmonics.

Following Berrara (<http://iopscience.iop.org/article/10.1088/0143-0807/6/4/014/meta>) we assume that any vector field, $\mathbf{V}$, and any scalar, g , can be expanded as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{V}(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{l=0}^{\infty} \sum_{m=-l}^l [a_{lm}(r) \mathbf{Y}_{lm}(\theta, \phi) + b_{lm}(r) \hat{\mathbf{r}} \times \mathbf{X}_{lm}(\theta, \phi) \\ + c_{lm}(r) \mathbf{X}_{lm}(\theta, \phi)] \end{aligned} \quad (10)$$

$$g(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{l=0}^{\infty} \sum_{m=-l}^l g_{lm}(r) Y_{lm}(\theta, \phi) \quad (11)$$

where Y_{lm} are the usual spherical harmonics (see Jackson 3.53), $\mathbf{Y}_{lm}$ is simply $\hat{\mathbf{r}} Y_{lm}$ and $\mathbf{X}_{lm}$ is defined as,

$$\mathbf{X}_{lm}(\theta, \phi) = \frac{-i}{\sqrt{l(l+1)}} \mathbf{r} \times (\nabla Y_{lm}(\theta, \phi)) \quad (12)$$

3.3 Recovery of Newtonian Gravity (Irrotational Solutions)

We now calculate Newtonian gravity as a solution to the Irrotational parts of the Maxwell equations.

In the case of a static point mass m located at the origin, we set:

$$\rho(\mathbf{x}) = m\delta^3(\mathbf{x}), \quad \mathbf{J} = 0 \quad (13)$$

Using the irrotational part of the Maxwell equations:

$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E}_I = -4\pi G\rho \quad \nabla \times \mathbf{E}_I = 0 \quad (14)$$

and using the spherical vector harmonics we developed earlier, we find:

$$\mathbf{E}_I(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{l,m} \left[-\frac{4\pi i G}{2l+1} \frac{q_{lm}}{r^{l+2}} \sqrt{l(l+1)} (\hat{\mathbf{r}} \times \mathbf{X}_{lm}) - \frac{4\pi G(l+1)}{2l+1} \frac{q_{lm}}{r^{l+2}} \mathbf{Y}_{lm} \right] \quad (15)$$

Where,

$$q_{lm} \equiv \int Y_{lm}^*(\theta, \phi) r^l \rho(\mathbf{x}) d^3x = \int \rho_{lm}(r) r^{l+2} dr \quad (16)$$

Clearly then, if

$$\rho(\mathbf{x}) = m\delta^3(\mathbf{x}) \quad (17)$$

We get

$$\mathbf{E}_I(\mathbf{x}) = -\hat{\mathbf{r}} \frac{mG}{r^2} \quad (18)$$

as expected.

3.4 Radiation from the Solenoidal Field (Solenoidal Solutions)

Several results from the solutions of the solenoidal Maxwell equations will be needed later; we now solve the corresponding equations.

Outside the mass, the solenoidal field equations in vacuum are:

$$\nabla \times \mathbf{E}_S + \partial_t \mathbf{B}_S = 0, \quad \nabla \times \mathbf{B}_S - \partial_t \mathbf{E}_S = 0 \quad (19)$$

Assuming time dependence $e^{-i\omega t}$, the general solution is expanded in vector spherical harmonics:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{B}_S &= \sum_{l,m} \left[a_E(l, m) f_l(kr) \mathbf{X}_{lm} - \frac{i}{k} a_M(l, m) \nabla \times (g_l(kr) \mathbf{X}_{lm}) \right] \\ \mathbf{E}_S &= \sum_{l,m} \left[\frac{i}{k} a_E(l, m) \nabla \times (f_l(kr) \mathbf{X}_{lm}) + a_M(l, m) g_l(kr) \mathbf{X}_{lm} \right] \end{aligned} \quad (20)$$

where $\mathbf{X}_{lm}$ was defined in (12).

The functions f_l and g_l are linear superpositions of the radial Hankel functions,

$$h_l^{(1)}(x) = -i(-x)^l \left(\frac{1}{x} \frac{d}{dx} \right)^l \left(\frac{e^{ix}}{x} \right) \quad (21)$$

$$h_l^{(2)}(x) = \left(h_l^{(1)}(x) \right)^* \quad (22)$$

a_E and a_M as well as the particular dependence of f_l and g_l on $h_l^{(1)}(x)$ and $h_l^{(2)}(x)$ depend on the boundary conditions.

In our case, we are looking at a massive particle that sinks radiation, we therefore need to only include incoming waves.

The total instantaneous power absorbed is defined as.

$$P \equiv \int_V d^3x \nabla \cdot \left(\frac{1}{8\pi} \mathbf{E} \times \mathbf{B}^* \right) = \oint_{\partial V} \hat{\mathbf{r}} \cdot \mathbf{S} da = R^2 \int d\Omega \hat{\mathbf{r}} \cdot \mathbf{S} \Big|_{r=R} \quad (23)$$

Using the relationships in the introduction on Vector Spherical harmonics, we find that we are left with only two non-vanishing terms,

$$P = \frac{R^2}{8\pi} \sum_{l,m} \left[\frac{-i}{k} |a_E|^2 h_l^{(2)} \frac{1}{r} \frac{d}{dr} \left(r h_l^{(1)} \right) + \frac{i}{k} |a_M|^2 h_l^{(1)} \frac{1}{r} \frac{d}{dr} \left(r h_l^{(2)} \right) \right]_{r=R} \quad (24)$$

Since, by assumption (See Section 2.1) the massive particle is electromagnetically neutral on average, we need neither the Transverse Magnetic nor the Transverse Electric modes to dominate. Thus, the two proportionality terms must obey $|a_E|^2 = |a_M|^2$. Use of the Wronskian leaves a particularly simple form for the power radiated,

$$P = \sum_{l,m} \frac{|a_E|^2}{4\pi k^2} \quad (25)$$

The associated energy and momentum densities in the radiation zone also follow cleanly. The total field momentum is directed radially inward:

$$\mathbf{P}_{\text{field}} = -\hat{\mathbf{r}} \sum_{l,m} \int_V \frac{|a_E|^2 |\mathbf{X}_{lm}|^2}{4\pi k^2 r^2} d^3x \quad (26)$$

The total field momentum:

$$\mathbf{P}_{\text{field}} = \frac{1}{8\pi} \int_V \mathbf{E} \times \mathbf{B}^* d^3x = -\hat{\mathbf{r}} \sum_{l,m} \int_V \frac{|a_E|^2 |\mathbf{X}_{lm}|^2}{4\pi k^2 r^2} d^3x \quad (27)$$

The total field energy:

$$U = \sum_{l,m} \int_V \frac{1}{4\pi} \frac{|a_E|^2 |\mathbf{X}_{lm}|^2}{k^2 r^2} d^3x \quad (28)$$

The specific coefficients $|a_E|^2$ will be fixed by boundary conditions in the section on collapse and stability. But, since we've already spelled out the hypothesis then we know we will eventually get to :

$$\boxed{\mathbf{p}(r) = -\hat{\mathbf{r}} \frac{Gm\hbar}{r^2}} \quad (29)$$

This result follows from boundary conditions at the mass's surface. In later sections, we will derive it explicitly, including the dependence on $\hbar$.

4 Stochastic Electrodynamics (SED)

To complete our framework, we now introduce the physical source of the radiation field: the zero-point background. Rather than assuming empty space, we posit—following the ideas of stochastic electrodynamics (SED)—that the vacuum is filled with a classical, Lorentz-invariant radiation field even at absolute zero. This field supplies the fluctuations from which mass sinks momentum.

In SED, zero-point radiation explains how classical systems can remain stable, even while radiating energy. It has been shown to reproduce:

- The Planck blackbody spectrum (Boyer, 1969) - Harmonic oscillator ground-state energy $\frac{1}{2}\hbar\omega$ - Casimir and van der Waals forces - Some features of the hydrogen atom ground state - The Unruh effect

(Note to self: get some actual references here)

Each of these suggests that the vacuum is not passive. It is a sea of fluctuating modes that constantly jostle matter—even at $T = 0$.

It is important to repeat or say for the first time, that in SED there is no need to quantize. The results are all derived by classical analysis.

4.1 The Zero-Point Radiation Field

In SED, the vacuum is not silent. It carries a random, omnipresent electromagnetic field with spectral energy density:

$$\rho(\omega) = \frac{1}{2}\hbar\omega \quad (30)$$

This spectrum is Lorentz-invariant and corresponds to the ground state energy per mode, in analogy to the quantum harmonic oscillator. But unlike quantum theory, which treats this as an abstract baseline, SED models it as a real classical field.

The field is stochastic and Gaussian, defined by:

$$\langle W \rangle = 0, \quad \langle W_i(\mathbf{k}) W_j^*(\mathbf{k}') \rangle = \delta_{ij} \delta^3(\mathbf{k} - \mathbf{k}') \quad (31)$$

The electric and magnetic fields are then:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbf{E}(\mathbf{x}, t) &= \text{Re} \sum_{\lambda=1}^2 \int d^3k \, \hat{\epsilon}(\mathbf{k}, \lambda) \sqrt{\frac{\hbar\omega}{2\pi^2}} W_{\lambda}(\mathbf{k}) e^{i(\omega t - \mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{x})} \\ \mathbf{B}(\mathbf{x}, t) &= \text{Re} \sum_{\lambda=1}^2 \int d^3k \, \frac{\mathbf{k} \times \hat{\epsilon}(\mathbf{k}, \lambda)}{k} \sqrt{\frac{\hbar\omega}{2\pi^2}} W_{\lambda}(\mathbf{k}) e^{i(\omega t - \mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{x})}\end{aligned}\tag{32}$$

This background field is homogeneous, isotropic, and defined over all frequencies up to some high-frequency cutoff (see **Section 5**). Each mode contributes an energy $\frac{1}{2}\hbar\omega$, and that the full ensemble of modes is statistically stationary and invariant under Lorentz transformations.

The zero-point radiation field plays a central role in the framework. Mass interacts with this field by absorbing momentum from it. This stands in contrast to general relativity, where mass is treated as a cold object sitting in empty space and curving spacetime around it.

5 Coupling Mass to the Field: Dual Cutoffs / Dual Infinities

A central feature of this theory is that mass interacts with the zero-point field only over a limited domain, defined by two natural cutoffs: one in space, and one in frequency. These cutoffs are not imposed arbitrarily, but emerge from physical consistency. The spatial cutoff prevents gravitational collapse, while the frequency cutoff ensures that absorption from the zero-point radiation field remains finite.

Interaction Hypothesis

We propose that a mass m couples to the zero-point field up to a maximum frequency

$$\omega \lesssim \frac{m}{\hbar}\tag{33}$$

and within a radial domain extending at least to

$$r \gtrsim Gm\tag{34}$$

This assumption is not yet derived, but it will prove physically consistent. In later sections, we show how this interaction yields a radial inward momentum density:

$$\boxed{\mathbf{p}(r) = -\hat{\mathbf{r}} \frac{Gm\hbar}{r^2}}\tag{35}$$

and how the constant in this expression emerges from the field equations and boundary conditions.

Lower Bound: Minimum Radius via Gravitational Self-Energy

From classical considerations, any spherically symmetric mass distribution has a gravitational self-energy:

$$U = -\frac{1}{2} \int \frac{Gm\rho(\mathbf{x})}{r} d^3x \quad (36)$$

For a spherical shell of radius R , this yields:

$$R = \frac{Gm}{2} \quad (37)$$

Other geometries differ only by numerical prefactors. In general, we require:

$$R \gtrsim Gm \quad (38)$$

We interpret this as a **minimum radius** for any stable mass. Unlike the Schwarzschild radius (which assumes collapse), this lower bound emerges as a stability criterion under constant zero-point radiation pressure.

Upper Bound: Cutoff Frequency via Energy Matching

Conversely, mass cannot absorb arbitrarily high-frequency radiation. A natural upper limit arises from energy conservation:

$$U = m = \hbar\omega_{\max} \quad \Rightarrow \quad \omega \lesssim \frac{m}{\hbar} \quad (39)$$

This sets the upper bound for momentum transfer and defines the domain of coupling between mass and field. While this frequency is extraordinarily high for macroscopic objects, it plays a crucial theoretical role in regularizing energy and momentum integrals.

Together, these dual cutoffs—one in radius, one in frequency—define a resolution scale for gravity. They constrain how mass interacts with the field and suggest a breakdown of classical behavior beyond these limits, potentially pointing toward extensions of the theory. This is also possibly a testable prediction.

6 Field Energy and Momentum Balance: A Mechanism for Stability

6.1 Stability from Field Energy

We now evaluate whether the inward radiation flow, hypothesized in **Section 2**, can provide a stabilizing mechanism for a massive particle. Specifically, we ask: can the absorbed energy from the zero-point field counteract the gravitational self-energy that would otherwise lead to collapse?

The total field energy is given by:

$$U = \frac{1}{16\pi} \int (|\mathbf{E}|^2 + |\mathbf{B}|^2) d^3x \quad (40)$$

From equation (28), we have

$$U_{\text{rad}} = \sum_{l,m} \int_V \frac{1}{4\pi} \frac{|a_E|^2 |\mathbf{X}_{lm}|^2}{k^2 r^2} d^3x \quad (41)$$

The energy density can thus be defined as

$$u_{\text{rad}} = \sum_{l,m} \frac{1}{4\pi} \frac{|a_E|^2 |\mathbf{X}_{lm}|^2}{k^2 r^2} \quad (42)$$

Taking the constants together, we rewrite this as

$$u_{\text{rad}} = \frac{\alpha}{r^2} \quad (43)$$

The energy density near a massive particle absorbing zero-point radiation falls off as $1/r^2$. Including the cutoff frequency $\omega_{\text{max}} = m/\hbar$, we have:

$$u_{\text{rad}}(r) = \int_0^{m/\hbar} \frac{\alpha}{r^2} d\omega = \frac{\alpha m}{\hbar r^2} \quad (44)$$

Our goal is to now find *alpha* such that energy is conserved.

We will show that there is conservation of energy, and therefor the massive particle introduced in the last section will not collapse (One could have also done this purely from a pressure standpoint, but Energy conservation seems cooler)

$$U_{\text{tot}} = \int_V u d^3x = \int_V \left(-\frac{1}{4\pi G} |\mathbf{E}_I|^2 + |\mathbf{E}_S|^2 + |\mathbf{B}_S|^2 \right) d^3x \quad (45)$$

$$U_{\text{tot}} = \int_V \left[-\frac{Gm^2}{4\pi r^4} + \frac{\alpha m}{\hbar r^2} \right] d^3x \quad (46)$$

And thus

$$u_{\text{tot}} = \left[-\frac{Gm^2}{4\pi r^4} + \frac{\alpha m}{\hbar r^2} \right] \quad (47)$$

If this is a constant at $r = R$, then energy is conserved. More to the point, if we say these two energies cancel each other out, then we are left with zero energy, thus we can write

$$\alpha = \frac{1}{4\pi R^2} Gm\hbar$$

and thus

$$u = \sum_{l,m} \frac{1}{4\pi} \frac{|a_E|^2 |\mathbf{X}_{lm}|^2}{k^2 r^2} = \frac{1}{4\pi R^2} \frac{Gm\hbar}{r^2}$$

Integrating over all space, assuming spherical symmetry:

$$U_{\text{rad}} = \int_0^\infty u(r) \cdot 4\pi r^2 dr = \int_0^\infty \frac{4\pi\alpha m}{\hbar} dr \quad (48)$$

This diverges unless we impose a lower bound, namely the minimum radius of the particle $R = Gm$. Truncating the integral from R to ∞ , we obtain:

$$U_{\text{rad}} = \frac{4\pi\alpha m}{\hbar} \int_R^\infty dr = \infty \quad (49)$$

To regularize this, we instead take the volume integral up to some finite domain or assume that most of the energy is absorbed near R . The key is not the total energy, but the ****balance**** between the field energy and the self-gravitational energy of the particle:

$$U_{\text{grav}} = -\frac{Gm^2}{R} \quad (50)$$

$$U_{\text{rad}} = \frac{4\pi\alpha m R}{\hbar} \quad (51)$$

Balancing these energies (assuming $U_{\text{total}} = 0$) gives:

$$-\frac{Gm^2}{R} + \frac{4\pi\alpha m R}{\hbar} = 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad \alpha = \frac{Gm\hbar}{4\pi R^2} \quad (52)$$

Substituting back, we find the energy density is:

$$u(r) = \frac{Gm\hbar}{4\pi R^2 r^2} \quad (53)$$

This shows that the particle's own radiation environment acts to resist collapse, provided the momentum flow structure is accepted. The directionality of $\mathbf{p} \propto -\hat{\mathbf{r}}$ also implies an inward pressure that balances gravitational pull.

6.2 Momentum Conservation and “Ohm’s Law”

We now turn to momentum conservation. The total momentum exchange in the system should obey:

$$\int_V (\rho \mathbf{E}_I + \mathbf{J}_S \times \mathbf{B}_S) d^3x = 0 \quad (54)$$

This relation balances the impulse from the irrotational field (associated with gravitational mass) against the magnetic impulse from the solenoidal radiation field.

Assuming the solenoidal current obeys a linear response:

$$\mathbf{J}_S = \sigma \mathbf{E}_S \quad (55)$$

and harmonic time dependence $e^{-i\omega t}$, the field momentum becomes:

$$-\hat{\mathbf{r}} \int \left(m\delta(\mathbf{x}) \cdot \frac{Gm}{r^2} - \sigma \cdot \frac{Gm\hbar}{r^2} \right) d^3x = 0 \quad (56)$$

Solving gives:

$$\sigma = \frac{m}{\hbar} \delta(\mathbf{x}) \quad (57)$$

This expression defines a delta-function conductivity concentrated at the origin — an effective Ohm's law in which the mass acts as a point-like, perfect absorber for incoming radiation. Including conventional normalization gives:

$$\sigma = \frac{m}{4\pi\hbar} \delta(\mathbf{x}) \quad (58)$$

This result is not imposed, but emerges from requiring consistency with the momentum flux model.

6.3 Summary

Together, the field energy and momentum conservation arguments demonstrate that the hypothesized momentum inflow can act as a self-consistent stabilizing structure. A massive particle that sinks zero-point radiation does not collapse — not due to internal structure, but due to interaction with the vacuum field itself.

7 Classical Tests of Gravity

This section demonstrates that the present theory reproduces three key experimental predictions of general relativity: the precession of Mercury's perihelion, the deflection of light near a massive object, and gravitational redshift. Each is derived from the momentum-transfer hypothesis introduced earlier.

7.1 Precession of the Perihelion of Mercury

In electrodynamics, a static Coulomb field transforms under Lorentz boosts into a configuration with both electric and magnetic components. Specifically, the fields of a charge moving at velocity $\mathbf{v}$ are:

$$\mathbf{E}' = \gamma \mathbf{E} - \frac{\gamma^2}{\gamma + 1} \mathbf{v}(\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{E}), \quad \mathbf{B}' = -\gamma \mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{E} \quad (59)$$

where $\gamma = 1/\sqrt{1 - v^2}$.

By analogy, we assume the same Lorentz transformation laws apply to gravity. We define the gravitational field:

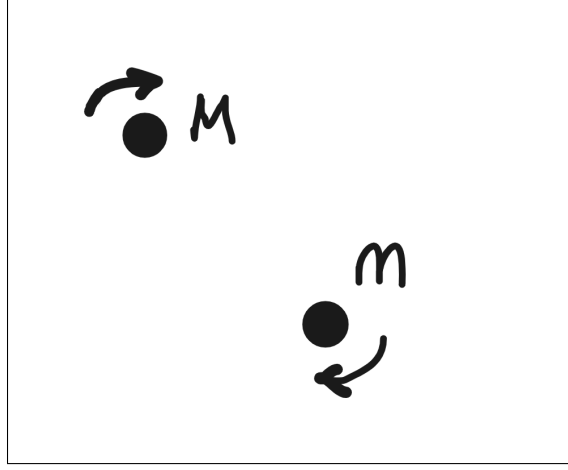


Figure 1: Two masses in mutual orbit

$$\mathbf{E}_g = \mathbf{F}/m = -\frac{GM}{r^3}\mathbf{r} \quad (60)$$

Then, under a Lorentz boost:

$$\mathbf{E}'_g = \gamma\mathbf{E}_g - \frac{\gamma^2}{\gamma+1}\mathbf{v}(\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{E}_g), \quad \mathbf{B}'_g = -\gamma\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{E}_g \quad (61)$$

In the low-velocity limit $v \ll 1$, we find:

$$\mathbf{B}_g = -\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{r} \cdot \frac{GM}{r^3} \quad (62)$$

This introduces a "gravitomagnetic" interaction analogous to magnetism in electrodynamics.

We now consider Kepler's problem. The Newtonian effective potential is:

$$U_{\text{Newt}} = \frac{1}{2}m\left(\frac{dr}{dt}\right)^2 - \frac{GMm}{r} + \frac{l^2}{2mr^2} \quad (63)$$

where $l = m|\mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v}|$ is the orbital angular momentum (see 1).

A moving charge induces a magnetic moment $\mathbf{m} = \frac{1}{2}e(\mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v})$. Replacing $e \rightarrow m$, we define a gravitational magnetic moment:

$$\mathbf{m}_g = \frac{1}{2}m(\mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v}) \quad (64)$$

The potential energy of this moment in a magnetic field is:

$$U = -\mathbf{m}_g \cdot \mathbf{B}_g = -\frac{GMm}{2}|\mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v}|^2/r^3 \quad (65)$$

This adds a correction to the potential energy. Including the reciprocal effect (from the motion of the central mass), we double this term and find the corrected potential:

$$U_{\text{Einstein}} = \frac{1}{2}m \left(\frac{dr}{dt} \right)^2 - \frac{GMm}{r} + \frac{l^2}{2mr^2} - \frac{GMl^2}{mr^3} \quad (66)$$

This is the same correction obtained in general relativity to first order. As Carroll notes, general relativity produces this result exactly; in our theory, it emerges as a first-order approximation. Higher-order terms may offer a route to testing deviations.

7.2 Deflection of Light

We now consider the bending of light near a massive object. Our central hypothesis is that mass creates a momentum-transfer field:

$$\mathbf{P}(r) = -\hat{\mathbf{r}} \frac{Gm\hbar}{r^2} \quad (67)$$

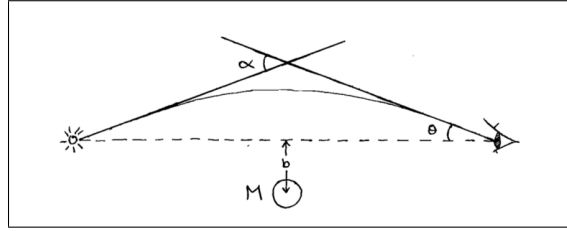


Figure 2: Deflection of light

A photon traveling through this field receives a cumulative momentum shift:

$$\Delta \mathbf{p} = \int_{\text{path}} \mathbf{P}(r) dl \quad (68)$$

Assuming a straight-line path passing at minimum distance b , we integrate:

$$\Delta \mathbf{p} = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} -\frac{Gm\hbar}{r^3} \mathbf{r} w dz \quad (69)$$

The parallel momentum shifts cancel symmetrically. The transverse component yields:

$$\Delta p_y = \hbar w \cdot \frac{2Gm}{b} \quad (70)$$

The angle of deflection is then:

$$\theta \approx \frac{\Delta p_y}{p_z} = \frac{2Gm}{b} \Rightarrow \alpha = \frac{4Gm}{b} \quad (71)$$

This matches the deflection angle predicted by general relativity.

7.3 Gravitational Redshift

Finally, we consider the redshift of light climbing out of a gravitational well. As before, a photon gains or loses momentum depending on its path through the momentum field.

Using:

$$\Delta p = \int_{\infty}^R \mathbf{P} \cdot \hat{\mathbf{r}} \cdot w \, dr = \int_{\infty}^R -\frac{Gm\hbar}{r^2} w \, dr = \hbar w \cdot \frac{Gm}{R} \quad (72)$$

The resulting frequency shift is:

$$\hbar w' = \hbar w + \Delta p = \hbar w \left(1 + \frac{Gm}{R} \right) \quad (73)$$

which, to first order, matches the prediction of general relativity for gravitational redshift.

8 Duality and the Dirac Equation

8.1 Duality Transformations

As discussed in Jackson (Section 6.11), the Maxwell equations can be extended to include both electric and magnetic charges:

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla \times \mathbf{B} - \partial_t \mathbf{E} &= \mathbf{J}_e, & \nabla \times \mathbf{E} + \partial_t \mathbf{B} &= -\mathbf{J}_m \\ \nabla \cdot \mathbf{E} &= \rho_e, & \nabla \cdot \mathbf{B} &= \rho_m \end{aligned} \quad (74)$$

The magnetic densities are assumed to obey the same continuity equation as their electric counterparts.

Now consider the following duality transformation:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{E} &= \mathbf{E}' \cos \xi + \mathbf{B}' \sin \xi, & \mathbf{B} &= \mathbf{B}' \cos \xi - \mathbf{E}' \sin \xi \\ \rho_e &= \rho'_e \cos \xi + \rho'_m \sin \xi, & \rho_m &= \rho'_m \cos \xi - \rho'_e \sin \xi \\ \mathbf{J}_e &= \mathbf{J}'_e \cos \xi + \mathbf{J}'_m \sin \xi, & \mathbf{J}_m &= \mathbf{J}'_m \cos \xi - \mathbf{J}'_e \sin \xi \end{aligned} \quad (75)$$

This transformation leaves the generalized Maxwell equations invariant. As Jackson notes, the distinction between electric and magnetic charge is, in this framework, a matter of convention. If all particles share the same magnetic-to-electric charge ratio, a duality rotation can eliminate magnetic charges entirely. This perspective opens the door for deeper reinterpretations of classical field theory.

8.2 Spinor Representation of Field Operators

We now examine a way to recast Maxwell's equations using spinor-like objects.

Define the vector curl as a matrix operator:

$$\nabla \times \mathbf{V} = g_i \partial_i \mathbf{V} \quad (76)$$

with:

$$g_1 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad g_2 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ -1 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad g_3 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \quad (77)$$

Define the gamma matrices as (These matrices satisfy the algebra of infinitesimal rotations and generate the curl operator in 3D):

$$\gamma^0 = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \gamma^i = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & g_i \\ -g_i & 0 \end{pmatrix} \quad (78)$$

These matrices are not the standard Dirac representation, but they serve to connect the structure of the field equations to the spinor formalism in a suggestive way. This could be further explored with tools from representation theory and Clifford algebras.

8.3 Emergence of the Dirac Equation

Recall from the section on momentum conservation that:

$$\nabla \times \mathbf{B}_S - \partial_t \mathbf{E}_S = -\frac{m}{\hbar} \mathbf{E}_S \delta^3(\mathbf{x}) \quad (79)$$

Restricting attention to the surface of the particle (i.e., “on-shell”), we drop the delta function and write:

$$\nabla \times \mathbf{B}_S - \partial_t \mathbf{E}_S = -\frac{m}{\hbar} \mathbf{E}_S \quad (80)$$

Now, apply the duality transformation and write the solenoidal Maxwell equations in this form:

$$\begin{aligned} -\partial_t \mathbf{E}_S + \nabla \times \mathbf{B}_S + \frac{m}{\hbar} \mathbf{E}_S &= 0 \\ -\partial_t \mathbf{B}_S - \nabla \times \mathbf{E}_S + \frac{m}{\hbar} \mathbf{B}_S &= 0 \end{aligned} \quad (81)$$

Using the spinor curl definition:

$$\begin{aligned} -\partial_t \mathbf{E}_S + g_i \partial_i \mathbf{B}_S + \frac{m}{\hbar} \mathbf{E}_S &= 0 \\ -\partial_t \mathbf{B}_S - g_i \partial_i \mathbf{E}_S + \frac{m}{\hbar} \mathbf{B}_S &= 0 \end{aligned} \quad (82)$$

Now define a six-component field:

$$\psi = \begin{pmatrix} \mathbf{E}_S \\ \mathbf{B}_S \end{pmatrix} \quad (83)$$

We can combine the two equations above into a compact form:

$$\left(\gamma^\mu \partial_\mu + \frac{m}{\hbar}\right) \psi = 0 \quad (84)$$

This has the exact form of the Dirac equation, as given in Sakurai’s Advanced Quantum Mechanics, Eq. 3.31.

This is a remarkable result: starting from classical field equations and a single added hypothesis, we arrive at a spinor field satisfying the Dirac equation—without invoking quantization or spin from the outset. It suggests that elements of quantum theory may emerge naturally from classical field dynamics under the right assumptions.

9 Discussion and Outlook

9.1 A Field, Not a Force

At first glance, the directional momentum flow described in this theory might resemble a gravitational force. But it is not. The core hypothesis postulates a momentum density field sourced by mass and arising from asymmetric absorption of zero-point radiation. The resulting momentum transfer acts on light but cannot be described by $\mathbf{F} = m\mathbf{a}$, nor does it require acceleration. It is not a mechanical push—it is field interaction.

This distinction is critical. In this model, light does not bend due to space-time curvature, but because its momentum evolves under the influence of a background field. Whether this counts as a “force” is secondary; mathematically, it is a field-driven momentum shift.

9.2 Experimental Implications and Testability

At low frequencies, this theory reproduces general relativity’s standard predictions to first order: perihelion precession, light deflection, and gravitational redshift. However, it introduces a natural high-frequency cutoff, $\omega_{\text{max}} = m/\hbar$, that could lead to deviations at high energies.

This sets the stage for falsifiability. Could light near ultra-dense masses bend slightly differently than GR predicts at near-Planckian frequencies? Might gravitational lensing data or high-precision interferometry detect subtle anomalies? These are open but well-posed questions.

Importantly, the theory comes with a scale—where it may transition, fail, or reveal something deeper. That is a feature, not a bug.

9.3 Scope and Limitations

This is an explicitly classical theory. It makes no claims about entanglement, Bell violations, or nonlocality. It treats the zero-point field as real but not quantized. It does not attempt to reconstruct quantum field theory or gauge symmetry from scratch.

Instead, it isolates one question: can gravitational behavior be modeled as a classical momentum interaction with the vacuum field? Within that scope, the answer appears to be yes.

9.4 Future Directions

Several paths remain unexplored:

- **Nonlinear interactions**: How do multiple nearby masses interact? Do momentum fluxes interfere? Is the field superposable?
- **Thermodynamic interpretations**: Can this model be linked to entropic gravity or energy-entropy relations? The presence of a directional momentum field invites statistical reinterpretation.
- **Toward quantization**: Is there a consistent path to quantize this model? Can radiation absorption be discretized or coupled to standard QFT?

9.5 Final Remarks

This paper is a prototype. It closes no doors and makes no sweeping claims. Its contribution is a single, sharp hypothesis: that mass sinks radiation and generates a field of momentum flux. From this, classical gravity-like behavior—and elements of quantum structure—appear to follow.

This is offered not as a conclusion, but as a beginning. Collaborators welcome.

Acknowledgments

This paper would not exist without the support of a few key people. First and foremost, I thank my wife, who has stood beside me for over two decades as I pursued this idea. Her patience, steadiness, and quiet encouragement through all the ups and downs have been unwavering.

I am also deeply grateful to my friend Michael Seidel, who—despite not having a background in physics—listened to me explain these ideas again and again over the years. His willingness to engage, ask questions, and simply be present helped me find clarity when I needed it most.

To both of them: thank you.